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PHOTOS BY SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

THE FERTILITY DIVIDE

Left out of the promise of pregnancy

A drug exchange in a parking lot. A \$300,000 baby. Even in Mass., IVF coverage shortfalls cost patients dearly.

By Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

It was midday when the nurse pulled her car into the Market Basket parking lot in Hanover and sidled up to a black SUV.

She said hello to the SUV driver, a suburban mom she'd connected with in a private Facebook group. The driver got out and handed the nurse a plastic bag. Inside, nestled in ice, were drugs worth thousands of dollars.

"Good luck," the woman said, then vanished into the grocery store to buy food for her family.

The nurse sighed with relief — she had

Top: Dr. Jamie Adler and her newborn, Coco, in their Needham home.

Below: Kara and Hannah Connor, at their home in Fall River, have spent more than \$25,000 on fertility treatments.



enough hormone shots for today. But tomorrow, she'd have to drive to Waltham to pick up another shot from another stranger, this one a licensed pharmacist.

Even though no money changed hands, she knew the whole thing might look sketchy.

But when you're struggling to have a baby in Massachusetts these days, you do whatever it takes.

The nurse hadn't expected in vitro fertilization to work this way. She had been trying to get pregnant with her husband for well over a year, but her husband didn't have insurance

IVF, Page A16

Physicians pressed to curb high billings

Blue Cross to scrutinize costly visits, threatens to reduce expensive charges

By Jonathan Saltzman
GLOBE STAFF

With the help of a computer algorithm, the state's biggest health insurer says it will scrutinize doctors who frequently bill it for the most expensive patient visits. It will then unilaterally cut payments to physicians it concludes charged too much.

Targeting what it described as a small percentage of "outliers," Blue Cross Blue Shield of Massachusetts plans to roll out the new program around Nov. 3. The insurer says health care costs are increasing at their fastest rate in more than 20 years and that it has a duty to help control them for its 3 million members.

But the move has angered some doctors, particularly those who often see older, medically complicated patients in need of more care and time. They say Blue Cross's initiative fails to recognize a simple fact of medicine: Patients and treatments don't fit neatly into categories used by insurers and software developers.

The dispute represents another front in the OVERBILLING, Page A20

Layoff anxiety has workers uneasy and sitting tight

'Job-hugging' reflects deep fear of limited prospects

By Janelle Nanos
GLOBE STAFF

They're ambitious, motivated, and want to make a career move. But in this economy? They're staying put.

That's the circumstance 23-year-old Claire, who works in marketing at a local tech firm, currently finds herself in.

The gig helped her move to Boston after college and become financially independent, she said, but the pay isn't great. She'd like to look for something better, but doesn't see many opportunities. So, as she's not confident it's smart to make a move right now, she's "holding onto this job tight."

"I think people feel the grind right now pretty heavily and the energy of corporate America is pretty depressing," said Claire, who asked to be identified only by her middle name to protect her privacy from her employer. "People are all a little nervous and unsure of where the economy is head-

JOBS, Page A21

Take a rake

Sunday: Clouds and sun.
High: 52-57. Low: 38-43.
Complete report, **B10**.
Deaths, **A21-26**.

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In the past 14 months, a new generation of museum leaders has taken the reins at three of the area's largest museums. Read about their plans and more in the museum issue of **SundayArts, N1**.

The Working Families Party, a longtime progressive force in New York politics, is launching a state chapter in Massachusetts in a bid to pull disillusioned working-class voters back to the left in the deep-blue state. **B1**.

'Agent of discord' or much-needed skeptic? MIT professor takes stage in vaccine debate.

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

CAMBRIDGE — Soon after MIT students returned to campus this fall, Retsef Levi, a professor of operations management who has been a vocal critic of COVID-19 vaccines, gave an informal talk about his new role leading a federal task force reviewing COVID-19 vaccine safety.

Then came the fallout: Levi was spreading conspiracy theories and murdering children, said one member in a WhatsApp group chat for MIT's Israeli and Jewish community. The messages kept coming: Ping, ping, ping! Other people were texting back, calling for the personal attacks to stop. At a certain point, a moderator kicked that member out.

Levi asked that the member be let back in.

The move signaled what people at MIT already know about Levi, who's a specialist in analyzing risks: He's not afraid of conflict. He welcomes it. He seeks it. Sometimes, he stirs it. And now, he's holding his ground in the turbulent, swirling center of it.

LEVI, Page B8

SHUTDOWN DAY 26

10

Failed Senate votes

Sept. 19

Date of last session

594,048

Workers furloughed

35 days

Longest-ever shutdown

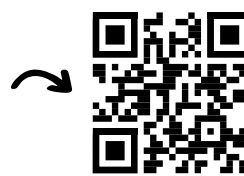
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